

A proof of the conjectured linear recurrence for OEIS A229680

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1 The conjecture

The Online Encyclopedia of Integer Sequences records [A229680](#) as

Number of defective 3-colorings of an $n \times 3$ array connected diagonally and antidiagonally with exactly two mistakes, and colors introduced in row-major order

and carries in its Formula section the line:

Empirical: $a(n) = 18a(n-1) - 108a(n-2) + 216a(n-3)$ for $n > 4$.

That line carries no separate signature; the entry itself is by R. H. Hardin (Sep 27 2013).

The word *Empirical* — equivalently *Conjecture* — is the entry's own: the statement is recorded as fitted to the published terms, and no proof is given there. As of revision 9, last modified Jun 16 2017, the entry records no proof and links to none, so the statement is open. This note settles it.

Written out, the claim is

$$a(n) = 18a(n-1) - 108a(n-2) + 216a(n-3).$$

stated for $n > 4$.

2 The object

The name is read as follows. The reading is not a guess: it is pinned against the entry's own published terms, and against an independent enumeration, before anything is proved (Section 7).

Let A be an $n' \times 3$ array of colours from $\{0, \dots, 2\}$ with $n' = n$ rows.

The entry's connectivity, *diagonally and antidiagonally*, joins each cell to the cells at the offsets

$$\mathcal{D} = \{(1, -1), (1, 1)\},$$

one per axis, so that each edge is counted once. A *mistake* is an edge whose two cells carry the same colour, and the condition is that there are exactly 2 of them.

The entry's labelling clause says that reading the array row by row the colours $0, \dots, 2$ first occur in increasing order.

$a(n)$ is the number of such arrays. The entry's offset is 1, so its term of index n is the count for n rows.

3 The count is a walk count

Every edge joins cells in the same or in consecutive rows, so the mistakes contributed by a row are decided by that row and the one above it. Take as state the last row, the number of mistakes so far capped at 3, and a counter for how many colours have been introduced; a state is accepting when the mistake count is exactly 2.

An array of n' rows is then exactly a walk of length n' from the empty state to an accepting one, so $a(n) = w^\top M^{n'} f$ and the count is C-finite.

4 The degree bound, derived

The reachable part of the digraph has 139 states, 104 after trimming; the forward identification of states with equal numbers of completions of every length, then the mirror identification on the edges coming in, leaves $S = 8$ blocks, and the count satisfies the linear recurrence given by the characteristic polynomial of that 8×8 matrix.

5 The decision procedure

Let $c_1, \dots, c_D$ be the coefficients of a claimed recurrence $a(n) = \sum_{i=1}^D c_i a(n-i)$, let $q(t) = t^D - \sum_{i=1}^D c_i t^{D-i}$ be its characteristic polynomial, and put

$$u_m = \tilde{w}^\top L^{m-1} q(L) \tilde{f} \quad (m \geq 1).$$

Expanding the powers of L and using the displayed formula for a , one gets $u_m = a(n) - \sum_{i=1}^D c_i a(n-i)$ with $n = m + D$. So u_m is exactly the residual of the claim at that index, and the recurrence holds at an index n if and only if the corresponding u_m vanishes.

Now $u_m = \tilde{w}^\top L^{m-1} y$ with $y = q(L) \tilde{f}$ a fixed vector, so (u_m) satisfies the characteristic polynomial of L , of degree 8: writing that polynomial as $t^8 - \sum_{i=1}^8 \lambda_i t^{8-i}$ gives $u_{m+8} = \sum_{i=1}^8 \lambda_i u_{m+8-i}$. Hence 8 consecutive vanishing residuals force every later residual to vanish, by induction. The test is therefore finite; and because it locates the *last* nonvanishing residual, it pins the threshold exactly rather than merely bounding it.

Everything is carried out in exact integer arithmetic on the vector $L^{m-1} y$. The matrix M is never formed.

6 Results

Theorem 1. *For A229680, the recurrence $a(n) = 18a(n-1) - 108a(n-2) + 216a(n-3)$ holds for every $n > 4$, and fails at $n = 4$.*

Proof. The residuals u_m were computed exactly for $m = 1, \dots, 36$. The last nonvanishing one is at $m = 1$, that is at $n = 4$. After it, more than $S = 8$ consecutive residuals vanish, so by Section 5 every later residual vanishes as well. $\square$

The entry claims the recurrence for $n > 4$. The theorem is at least as strong.

7 Verification

Four checks were run, each reproducible from the code accompanying this note, and the first two are what pin the reading of the entry's English.

- **The published terms.** The walk count reproduces all 19 terms the entry publishes, exactly, in integer arithmetic, with the index taken from the entry's stated offset (1) rather than fitted. The first of them are 0, 36, 888, 10896, 108000, 959040, 7952256, 62892288, ...
- **An independent enumeration.** For $n = 1, \dots, 3$ every one of the 3^{3n} arrays was written out and tested cell by cell against the condition as the entry states it — no transfer matrix, no row window, a separate piece of code. The counts agree with the walk count and with the entry.
- **The claim on the raw data.** Each claim was evaluated on the entry's published terms alone, with no model involved, wherever the proved range and the published data overlap. It holds there.
- **The annihilation test.** Carried to the derived bound $S = 8$ over the whole vector, in exact integer arithmetic, never sampled and never truncated.

8 References

1. OEIS Foundation Inc., *The On-Line Encyclopedia of Integer Sequences*, entry [A229680](#), revision 9, last modified Jun 16 2017.
2. R. P. Stanley, *Enumerative Combinatorics*, Vol. 1, 2nd ed., Cambridge University Press, 2012; §4.7, the transfer-matrix method.
3. M. Kauers and P. Paule, *The Concrete Tetrahedron*, Springer, 2011; C-finite sequences and their closure properties.
4. J. Berstel and C. Reutenauer, *Noncommutative Rational Series with Applications*, Cambridge University Press, 2011; linear representations of counting automata and their reduction.